

PREMISE DELTA v0.4 · THE TRUSTING FORGERY, REWORKED · 2026-09-09

Fourth delta against premise v8.1 and spine v1.4 with amendments v1.5 to v1.8. v0.3 (2026-09-08) was attacked by two adversaries on the same frozen text: Fable returned REWORK and GPT returned REJECT. Their ten findings were merged in order of fatality and walked with Stephen one at a time on 2026-09-09; every row was answered from the world and accepted (four-keys-premise-delta-trusting-forgery-disposition-2026-09-09.md). This document is v0.3 with those ten answers built in. It goes back to both adversaries fresh. Premise v8.1 remains in force until this survives and Stephen rules.

A note to the reviewer: the previous round's findings and their answers are summarised in section 8. Attack the answers. A finding already answered there, re-raised without engaging the answer, does not count.

1. The device

Before (v8.1, ruled). A dead woman's accusation tears four friends apart. Her key letter: I think one of you is planning to kill me. The locker letter, forged: I know. Chapter 7: dead women don't get surer.

After (v0.4). A woman who trusted four people completely asked them, from behind a padlocked door, to find out who had been getting into her house. She said it was none of them. Within a month the four were sure it was one of them. Violet never accuses anyone. The accusation is built at Ruby's kitchen table by the four themselves, out of true things, and the true things were chosen by the one of them who killed her. Brad does not forge her fear. He forges her trust, keeps her voice and her instruction, and salts the list so that four honest, frightened people, doing what she asked, arrive at Liam. They convict a man she cleared, against her written word, and the thing that lets them cross her word out is not a character reading but a locked house, a body at the foot of the stairs and a spare key exactly where it should be.

Everything downstream holds as ruled: the room lands on Liam, Margo keeps her silence, Brad vanishes off Kestrel Head on Day 60, Margo dies there on Day 214, the survivors accuse each other to the police, the police look properly and find nothing, Ruby talks to the Gazette, Ally begins.

2. Violet

Forty-four, the best judge of a hand on the coast, and she writes everything down. This autumn, two things inside her own house. Her tobacco, two a day rolled from the tin under the stairs among the paints and the garden concentrates, comes up stained through the paper; the lid is loose; the capped bottle on the shelf above has moved six inches or has not. She bins the tobacco that day and does not smoke from that tin again. And a gilded alphabet panel comes down out of her workshop roof with a ceiling board: her own alphabet, better than she has ever done it, signed with a mark that is not a name.

She carries the panel round the trade asking whose hand it is: the café, the cinema, two other signwriters. Two say yours, in a very good year. She does not show it to the four. Not fear, not shame: a professional exclusion and a teacher's pride. The one hand in the world trained in her alphabet is Brad's, and she never taught him to lay leaf and he has never asked, so it is not his; and to show her pupil a piece of her own work she cannot account for, and that is better than hers, is a confession she will not make. After the trade has said yours twice,

the question she asked is answered, and neither of the two readings left to her (I made it and don't remember; someone who studied me made it) sends her to him. The other three are not lettering people; a signwriter carrying a panel is not news to them. Nobody in town knows Brad can gild; his public work is boat names and pub signs.

She believes someone with her spare key has been in her house. She also believes, on alternate days, that she is imagining it. She does not suspect any of the four for a second, and the reason she does not call them is not fear of them: she has nothing to show them but a loose lid and a panel she may have made herself, and she would rather be laughed at after she is gone than watched while she is here. So she does what she does with everything. She writes it down. She changes the padlock on her store at the slip boatsheds (a closed-shackle marine padlock; it is where she keeps her hull kit, and the things she will not leave in a house someone else can enter), has four keys cut on Lantern Street, locks the letter behind the door with the panel, and lodges four bare notes with her solicitor to be posted after her funeral. He asks; she makes a joke about her sister. Then she gets on, calmer, because it is out of her head. She does not expect it to be needed.

3. The three letters, sketched (Fable writes prose, blind)

The key letter (genuine; four identical copies; posted Saturday Day 12; three by home delivery, one to a post office box). If you've got this, I'm dead, and I'm sorry about the timing. Go to my store at the boatsheds by the slip. The padlock's new and these four keys are the only ones. Go together, all four of you, and read what's there together. Violet. Nothing else: no trust stated, no fear, no police, and nothing that dates the letter behind the door.

The locker letter (genuine; Brad reads it at 07:20 on Day 14; burned in her sink that afternoon with the drafts and the debt book). It isn't any of you four, and I'd know. Someone with my key has been in my house, or I have started imagining things, and I cannot tell which, and both frighten me. The tin: the two a day she lies about, the stain through the paper, the loose lid, the bottle on the shelf above; I don't know whether I did that; I've thrown the tobacco out. The panel: the leak, the board, her own alphabet done better than she can do it, a mark for a name, two people in the trade who said yours; it isn't Brad's, I never taught him leaf; I don't know whether I made it, and if I didn't, somebody has been in my roof. Mum, on the shelf in the back bedroom, facing the door one morning when I leave her facing the window. Then: each of you write down everything odd you've noticed this year, about each other and about me, however small, and read the four lists together at one table. Then the police, with something in your hands. Write legibly. Brad reads it and knows what the room never will: pooled, the odd things name him (Ruby holds the marathon he called a wedding; Liam heard him price the van from the crane cab; Margo holds the debt and the calling-in), and the panel names a gilder.

The locker letter (forged; what the four read at nine that night). Her paper, her pen, her hand, one long day at her bench with the debt book open beside him for her cursive. Her frame, kept: it isn't any of you four, and I'd know; someone with my key has been in my house, or I'm imagining it, which frightens me more. Her reason for the scale, in her voice: I don't think I'm going to die. I think I'm going to be sixty and embarrassed. But I'm putting this where it can't be got at, because if I'm wrong nobody needs to know, and if I'm right you'll want to know what I noticed. If I'd told you now you'd have sat in my kitchen with a torch and I'd never have heard the end of it. The object: I have put Mum in here with this. One morning last month she was facing the door, and I leave her facing the window. Somebody has been in the back bedroom, or I have started moving things and forgetting. Either way she is not staying on a shelf for whoever it is to stand and look at. Keep her where all four of you can see her until this is sorted. Her instruction, kept: write down

everything odd you've noticed this year, about each other and about me, and read it together at one table. Then, "since I'm asking you to, here's mine", bare fact only, nothing she was not present for: Liam has owned a third of the yard for eight years and lets the town think he's staff. Liam asked in March and again in July to take Mum out to the point on his boat; I said no both times. Brad told us a wedding in the spring and ran a marathon; I saw his time. His one addition: not the police. I've nothing they'd act on and I won't have them in your lives over a shelf. You four can do what they won't. Her close, kept: read this together, be careful, write legibly.

What he cut: the tin (a poisoning in her hand sends a nurse to the police through any ban), the panel (it names a gilder), every word about money (Margo holds the names and sums), and every date. What he added: the ban, and three true things that lean one way. The lean is in the choosing, never in a sentence.

4. Brad on the night, and the fourteen days

He comes about the money; she goes up for the debt book; the landing. In the twenty minutes he waits he reads her book of everything, and in her hand, dated: padlock changed, four keys cut on Lantern Street, four envelopes lodged with the solicitor, letter and the thing in the store. He learns that a letter exists and where, not what it says. He takes her mother off the shelf because he already knows he will need something of hers beside whatever he writes, and she is the one thing in the house he can be sure Violet would lock away. Out by the back door at 22:30, latched; the neighbour at N^o14 sees a man's back and nothing in his hands (the tube is in the rucksack he brought for the book).

He does not go near the padlock for fourteen days, and it is the least-cost choice for this man, not a lapse. Nobody else can open the store before the keys arrive, so an unread letter behind a lock is inert. A cut or picked lock is the one event in the story that makes the police look: four people with keys, an empty store, a week after a letter told them to read what was there together, and the intruder she described is a fact on a file. His method from the tin to the stairs is that nothing is ever visibly wrong. A closed-shackle marine padlock cannot be shimmed; picking is a skill he does not have and cannot practise on hers; the sheds are worked from first light, so an early visit has the same witness on any day and a torch at two in the morning is what gets remembered. His own locker beside hers is a reason to be there at seven, and his PO box gives him seven. He waits for the post.

5. The room, week by week (replaces spine rows 14 to 60 in substance)

Day 14, 21:00. Torches, the padlock, a letter in her hand and her mother beside it. Margo: she's brought her mum. Brad hands Ruby the letter and lets Liam be the one who reaches. Liam carries the tube to Ruby's car, footwell not boot. Read that night at Ruby's table. The first response is relief, and then the shame of relief. Liam explains March and July the moment they are read: it had been four years; I thought if somebody offered she wouldn't have to be the one to decide. Ruby names the one line that did not sound like Vi: the police one. Weekly meetings agreed. The tube on Ruby's sideboard, label to the wall because that is how Liam set it down.

Day 15. The key question, because they are competent adults. Liam answers it, because he found her: front locked, back latched, the spare still in the meter box where it always lives. Five people knew that box, and one is dead. That is the sentence that crosses out "it isn't any of you", and nobody in the room says it aloud that day.

Meeting 1 (Day 19). The lists begin. Liam confirms the third of the yard; the letter has told one truth and earned the rest. Ruby says the line the room needs, and nobody answers it, because answering means saying Vi fell: she thought she'd know, and she's dead.

Meeting 2 (Day 26). Everything odd about Violet. The shelf. Who had been in the back bedroom this year. Liam, honestly: once, the window catch, spring. Margo underlines Spring.

Meeting 3 (Day 33). March and July, again, now beside the catch and the key. Brad: that's Liam, he'd have thought that. Ruby: Vi didn't write down things that didn't bother her. Nobody looks at the sideboard. The room hears an ordinary explanation given quickly as one given before; it hears a kindness about her mother as an interest in the back bedroom. That is what a frightened room does to the quiet man, and it is what the later chapters indict the room for.

Meetings 4 and 5 (Days 40, 47). The lists worked against each other; Ruby drives; Brad defends Liam each time, reasonably, and loses. About Day 40 the sister, as executor, asks Margo to close Violet's books for probate. By Day 47 it has landed on Liam without one line of the letter having said it. Margo, alone at the sideboard for as long as it takes Ruby to say goodbye upstairs: a quarter turn of the label, and back.

Days 47 to 53. Margo. She works the autumn as a ledger for the estate: what Violet said she was calling in (Day -120, the note in Margo's own file, Brad and the sum), what came in, which from him is nothing. She writes what a professional writes about a loan made on no paper by a client who refused paper when told to take it: no receivables evidenced. Her own omission, and Violet's choice she is keeping, not Brad's. Then she reads the letter again with the figures beside it, and reads it for what is not there. A letter in Violet's hand that lists everything odd about her year and never mentions the money she spent the autumn calling in; the debt book gone from a locked house since Day 8; and at a table convened to list everything odd, the one man who was called in has said nothing, and he is the man defending Liam. It is a reading, not a proof, and she cannot take it anywhere: a client's confidence, an omission is not evidence, and the man it points at is the one arguing for the man the room has chosen. **Day 54, meeting 6:** she stops arguing with Brad and stops looking at the other two. Brad, who has read her true letter and knows exactly what Margo holds, is the only one in the room who can read that silence, and he does. **Day 60:** Kestrel Head, as ruled. From there as ruled: Ruby drives the three; Day 77 Tessa's screenshot, word for word; the withdrawals; Day 214; the review; the Gazette; Ally.

6. Chapter 7: the box number

By chapter 4 Ally holds, from the boat owner via the Tip Line and unaided, that "the young one" was at Violet's locker at twenty past seven on the Monday morning. By chapter 6 she holds the panel from the two signwriters and the calling-in from the café. In chapter 7 Ruby gives her the envelope: the solicitor's covering slip and postmark. Four envelopes posted together on the Saturday, three to home addresses and one to a box number. A box is cleared first thing; home delivery came after work. One of the four held his key by seven, and the boat owner saw him use it at twenty past. The letter the four read together at nine that night had been in his hands since morning, with a day at her bench between. A document and a witness agree on a time; one man is named without a word about handwriting. Everything else is what he did with the fourteen hours: a letter that asks for everything odd and contains neither the panel the town saw her carry nor the money the town heard her call in; a letter kind to exactly one man; the one line that did not sound like Vi. Consequences, not the turn.

7. What changes, what does not

Changes. The premise device. The cold open's middle (two versions to the three blind readers, section 9). Chapter 1 packages 4 to 6; chapter 2 packages 2, 3, 8 and 10; chapter 7. Spine: A1 (Day 0 debt book; the ashes; no board; the padlock), B1 rows 5a/5b retired and new rows for the ashes, Liam's two requests, the sister's belief, the executor; B3 rows 25 to 30 (the store letter's claims); C2 Brad (Day 0 knowledge, the fourteen days); C5 Margo (the probate accounts; no receivables evidenced); D2/D3; R16 retired. The key letter ruled 2026-09-05 is void; the bare note replaces it. Terminology per v1.8.

Does not change. The motive (the van money, called in for the fight with the sister; lent on no paper by Violet's choice). The panel (her alphabet, his mark) and the dosed tin as what frightened her into the locker. Brad's PO box, dawn read and same-night swap (v1.7). His nine hundred days, the deckhand's papers, the vanish, the arrest under the deckhand's name on Day 333. Margo's six-week silence as the load-bearing lock, and her death. The survivors' fear of each other, the police look (row 25, R27), the Gazette, Ally's ten weeks. All four decisions. The notch. The two survivors' refusal to name what stood beside the letter, which needs no explaining.

8. The ten findings of the v0.3 round and their answers (attack these)

#	Finding (Fable / GPT)	Answer built into v0.4
1	Brad's least-cost action on Day 0 is to defeat the padlock (GPT's driver)	Section 4: a damaged lock is the one event that makes the police look; unread evidence behind a lock nobody can open is inert; closed-shackle marine padlock; the sheds worked from first light; his own locker and PO box give him seven o'clock legitimately.
2	Chapter 7 is an inference from a "starter list" (Fable's driver)	Section 6: the turn is the solicitor's slip, the box number and the dawn sighting agreeing on a time. "To show you what I mean" is gone. The town knows she was calling in money; only Margo knows names and sums.
3	The machinery's scale; the tin cut; "loose lid"; the solicitor; pride	Sections 2 and 3: the true letter keeps the tin and excludes Brad's hand as a fact (never taught leaf); the forgery drops the lid and carries her reason for the scale in her voice. The solicitor and dead-man points are v8.1 exposures (C1 row -3, passed), carried to the spine's list.
4	Margo: Day 8 to the executor; Day 19 to 51 with no arrival; Brad kills over a silence	Section 5: no paper by Violet's choice; the sister is the executor; "no receivables evidenced"; the probate accounts are the Day 47 to 51 arrival; Brad's read of her silence is v8.1 unchanged.
5	The key question; Liam's "she wrote it wasn't me"; the arithmetic	Section 5: Day 15, the meter box; Ruby's line at meeting one; Liam lands on access and history, not character; "within a month".
6	The sister and the ashes	Section 2 and the sweep: the sister believed them scattered on Violet's word after the funeral and had not been in the house in four years; on Day 5 she takes the barrel and the keys. Liam found Violet on Day 1; the tube left at 22:30 on Day 0.
7	Liam can contradict "he didn't ask why"	Section 3: bare fact only in every salted item; Liam's truthful explanation on night one is what the room later hears as practised.
8	Ruby to Del on Day 15 licenses a canvass	Row 25 and R27: statement, examination (weeks; consistent), coroner's officer (nothing), no tampering hypothesis so no canvass; the story survives either branch; the ban stays and Ruby flags it.
9	"The ninth" is investigable	Section 3: no date in the forgery.
10	The first minute is a summary	Section 9: a test, not a ruling.

9. The first minute: the test

Two versions of the open's middle go to the three blind readers with the ruled v0.4 open as control. Version A as sketched under ruling 6 of 2026-09-08 (she said someone had been getting in; she said it wasn't any of them; she said she might be imagining it; she wasn't; she was dead; within a month the four she trusted with the only keys were sure it was one of them; only two of them are still alive). Version B brings "only two of them are still alive" and the tin's image, the tobacco stained through the paper, inside the first sixty seconds. One question at the minute mark, unprompted: what are you afraid of right now. Nothing is ruled until the readers answer.

10. The new facts, swept

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
Brad knows of the store from Day 0	Brad	Defeat the padlock	Section 4: costs him the one thing his method forbids	Yes
The ashes off the shelf	The sister (executor; keys from Day 5)	Ask the four; ask police	She believes them scattered for four years and does not know the shelf; if she asks after Day 14 the survivors say what the letter says	Yes
Liam's two requests	Liam	Explain on night one	He does; the room hears practised	Yes
The meter box	The four	Check it Day 15	The spare is there; five people knew; one is dead	Yes: it is the room's turn
The forged ban	Ruby	Del, Day 15	Row 25; R27; either branch survives	Yes
Margo's ledger	Margo	Book the debt to the estate; tell the room; tell Del	No paper by Violet's choice; a note of a conversation is not a receivable; a client's confidence; an omission is not evidence	Yes
The panel never shown to the four	Violet	None; a fact about a hand	Brad hears from the café on Day -40 as ruled	Yes
No date in the forgery	The room	Alibi the intrusion	Nothing to alibi against; back to access	Yes
The four bare notes	The four	Go to the store first	The notes say together; the keys arrive together; the one who does not wait is seen	As v1.7

PROMPT FOR CHATGPT (paste everything below this line)

You are the adversarial reviewer for a true-crime mystery in production. This premise change was attacked in its previous version by two reviewers and reworked on their findings; section 8 lists those findings and the answers now built in. Your job is to break the reworked version, not to improve it. Read the delta above in full. Attack on six fronts. For each front, find the strongest objection you can, state it plainly, say whether it is fatal, serious or cosmetic, and say what would have to be true for it to be answered. A finding from the previous round re-raised without engaging its answer in section 8 does not count; if you think an answer fails, say exactly where it fails. Do not soften. Do not propose alternative stories. No scores, no percentages. No em dashes.

The fronts:

1. **Brad's fourteen days.** Section 4 argues that waiting is his least-cost action. Break the argument, not the conclusion: find the day and the act by which he does better than waiting without making anything visibly wrong.
2. **The room.** Section 5 turns the room against Violet's own clearance with the meter box on Day 15 and Ruby's line at meeting one. Does that earn the inward turn, or is it still four people auditing each other? Find the line one of them says that the delta has not answered.
3. **Margo.** Her lock is now a reading with a ledger under it and the probate accounts as its arrival. Find her earliest competent action after Day 47 and say what happens. Then find the reason an executor sister does not chase a debt her accountant knows about.
4. **Chapter 7.** The turn is the box number: the solicitor's slip, the postmark and the dawn sighting agreeing on a time. Does it turn, or does it only place a man at a door? What does the room, or Ally, still have to assume?
5. **Violet.** She excludes Brad's hand because she never taught him leaf, and she never shows the four the panel. Find the earliest moment a competent person in her life makes her show it to him anyway, or asks her why she has not.
6. **The new and changed facts.** Take each in turn (the closed-shackle padlock; the sister's belief that the ashes were scattered; "no receivables evidenced"; the undated forgery; the meter box as the room's turn) and find the earliest competent action any person in the story could take on it that ends the episode before its time.

End with one paragraph: PROCEED, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, TEST BEFORE COMMITTING, REWORK or REJECT, with your confidence and the single finding that most drives the verdict.